NAPOLEONIC WARS

RETURNING FROM HIS ILL-FATED EXPEDITION to Egypt, Napoleon made himself ruler of France as First Consul in 1799, and declared himself Emperor in 1804. He continued France's Revolutionary Wars, but with megalomanic ambition replacing ideological aspirations. Britain had no hope of resisting Napoleon's armies, which dominated in Europe, and was thus utterly dependent upon its naval strength. The French could not hope to contest this on their own, but could challenge in alliance with other naval powers. In 1800 the formation of an anti-British League of Armed Neutrality by the Scandinavian countries under Russian leadership threatened to block Britain's access to essential naval supplies from the Baltic. Decisive action by Nelson at Copenhagen showed how seriously the British took this threat. A greater peril for Britain arose when Napoleon assembled an invasion force on the Channel coast in 1805. Nelson's famous victory at Trafalgar both scotched the invasion plans and ended the naval war as a contest of fleets. Through the last decade of the Napoleonic Wars there were many smaller actions fought, but the Royal Navy's command of the sea was unshakeable.

THE BATTLE OF COPENHAGEN

Hoping to detach Denmark from the Russian-led League of Armed Neutrality, Britain assembled a fleet at Yarmouth in eastern England under Admiral Sir Hyde Parker, with Vice Admiral Nelson as second-in-command. Parker's orders were to see if the Danes would agree to abandon the league and, if not, open hostilities. Once Denmark was overcome, he was to enter the Baltic and attack the Russians. Nelson was for speedy and decisive action; Parker prevaricated. Even he was aware, though, that the question of Denmark must be settled before the winter ice melted, releasing the Russian fleet from its ports.

On March 30, the British fleet sailed through the narrows between Sweden and Denmark to confront the Danish fleet in front of Copenhagen. The Danes took up a strong defensive position with a line of ships and floating batteries anchored in the King's Channel in front of Copenhagen. The attackers would have to sail through shallow waters and past treacherous shoals, and would also come under fire from the powerful Trekroner shore battery at the northern end of the channel. This mission was entrusted to Nelson with 12 ships of the line—those with the shallowest draft—supported by frigates, sloops, and bomb-ketches. Nelson's plan was simple. His ships would sail in line and each would anchor opposite an opponent to blast it with broadsides. When enough of the Danish guns were silenced, the bomb-ketches would move forward and threaten Copenhagen with mortars, obliging the Danes to cede.

"DOWNRIGHT FIGHTING"

The operation began on the morning of April 2. Initially it was a disaster. Captain Hardy had spent the previous night in a rowing boat taking soundings of the channel, but to no avail. One of Nelson's ships of the line ran aground immediately and two more were stuck on the shoal known as the Middle Ground. Nelson pressed on regardless. His flagship *Elephant* and the other ships duly anchored a cable's length from their

Pocket telescope
Legend relates that Nelson lifted his telescope to his blind eye at Copenhagen, allowing him to ignore Admiral Parker's signal to withdraw. The story is almost certainly apocryphal.

